

GEARING UP Union home minister Amit Shah at a function with CM Bommai in Bengaluru, March 26, where he defended the exclusion of Muslims from OBC quota

KARNATAKA

PERCENTAGE POLITICS

a 'proactive' step, pointing to how reservation for religious minorities in Andhra Pradesh was challenged in court and struck down. Since eligibility criteria such as income apply to both the OBC and EWS categories, there will be no change for Muslims in shifting from II(b), he reasoned. "In fact, from 4 per cent, without any change of condition, they will be going into a 10 per cent pool," the CM said.

"It is a clear eyewash. There is no legal sanctity for all this," says C.S. Dwarakanath, a former chairman of the Karnataka Backward Classes Commission, explaining that any changes to the OBC list must be done on the basis of a report by the commission, relying on empirical evidence. So far, the government is only citing an interim report. "If they shift the Muslims to EWS, then what about the other communities which are in the backward classes list like Christians, Jains, Sikhs, Buddhists?" asks Dwarakanath.

On March 26, Union home minister Amit Shah congratulated the Karnataka government for doing away with the reservation on religious grounds, which he said had been brought in by previous governments "greedy for a vote bank". But experts point out that Karnataka's pioneering steps in affirmative action for various groups including Muslims—dating back over a century to the Mysore princely state—were based on social backwardness. The current move is "most unscientific," says Prof. S. Japhet of the National Law School of India University, Bengaluru. Where is the "data to show that Muslims have socially or economically improved" to be categorised as EWS, he asks.

"Will this stand in court? Why are you pitting communities against each other?" asked C.M. Ibrahim, state president of the Janata Dal (Secular), at a rally on March 26, pointing out that the II(b) category was created in 1994 when H.D. Deve Gowda was chief minister. "We are not interested in the 4 per cent quota. The Lingayats and Vokkaligas are not beggars," says Karnataka Congress president D.K. Shivakumar, vowing to scrap the move if voted to power.

The BJP, meanwhile, is hoping the reservation rearrangement will give it an edge in the coming elections. However, with the internal reservations for SC groups sparking off protests against the party in Shivamogga and Bagalkot this week, especially by the Banjara community, the key question is whether the gambit will pay off. ■

RISING RESERVATIONS

OBC category/castes

(Figures in percentage)

